FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The past, in India, refuses to rest in peace. Like a restless spectre, it keeps returning to haunt the living—fuelling anger, inciting debate, and increasingly dictating the direction of our political discourse. What ought to have remained the domain of scholars and classrooms has entered the courtrooms, assemblies, and even the theatres of violence out on the streets. This week's cover story examines a phenomenon that is no longer an anomaly but a pattern: the weaponisation of history for political ends. It is a subject both urgent and uncomfortable. In Maharashtra, the latest flashpoint is not a present-day economic crisis or infrastructure challenge but the grave of a long-dead Mughal emperor—Aurangzeb, who died in 1707.

What lit the fuse was the film *Chhaava*, a historical epic centred on Sambhaji, son of Chhatrapati Shivaji. In a 40-minute climax, it portrays Sambhaji's gruesome torture at the hands of Aurangzeb in agonising detail. Powerful performances by Vicky Kaushal and Akshaye Khanna ensured emotions were not confined to the screen. They spilled over—into social media, the Maharashtra assembly, and finally the streets. The debate that followed was less about art, more about ancestry, identity and indignation. A sitting MLA, Abu Azmi, found himself suspended from the assembly for offering a sympathetic take on Aurangzeb. Hindutva activists called for the demolition of the emperor's "tomb" in Khultabad, a grave that had lain unbothered for centuries—even during Maratha rule. Alleged desecration of Islamic symbols triggered riots in Nagpur, leaving one dead.



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Maharashtra is not alone in being drawn into this time warp. Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and other states have seen similar eruptions—fights over mosques, temples, dargahs, forgotten rulers and faded manuscripts. The Gyanvapi mosque case in Varanasi, the legal contest in Sambhal over the Shahi Jama Masjid, and the vilification of Moinuddin Chishti's dargah in Ajmer all point to a deeper malaise: an India increasingly divided not by what it faces today, but by how it remembers yesterday. This is not an accidental recurrence. It is the manifestation of a deliberate strategy. Even after the Supreme Court's Ayodhya verdict sought to put a cap on fresh disputes, the movement to seek revenge for history has only gathered pace. Even the RSS chief, Mohan Bhagwat, has called for closure, saying, "We shouldn't be looking for shivlings under every mosque." Yet, the movement seems to be doing precisely that. Legal challenges have been mounted to the Places of Worship (Special Provisions) Act, 1991, which was designed to shelter such monuments from fresh attacks or litigation. The court's verdict on its constitutionality is still awaited.

While RSS spokespersons like Sunil Ambekar have called debates on Aurangzeb "not relevant", affiliates like the VHP remain vocal and active. "We are against Aurangzeb's glorification," says VHP president Alok Kumar. "The VHP is working to build monuments to commemorate those heroes who stood against him." This multi-voiced chorus may appear chaotic, but insiders say it syncs with the ideological diversity within the Sangh ecosystem—and aligns with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "panch pran" (five resolves) of Amrit Kaal, which includes the goal of eliminating every trace of the "colonial mindset".

Therein lies the deeper dilemma. Whose version of history are we cleansing? And who decides what is a "colonial mindset"? Is the desire to reclaim pride in civilisational identity incompatible with democratic plurality? Can a modern nation afford to be so preoccupied with medieval wrongs that it forgets to correct contemporary injustices? This cover story does not simply chronicle controversy—it asks fundamental questions. When historical memory is used as political fuel, it becomes combustible. We are witnessing how easily old symbols can be recast into present-day provocations.

Author Amish, in his guest column, calls for "civilisational honour", suggesting Aurangzeb's bones be respectfully sent to Pakistan. Historian Purushottam Agrawal warns against reducing Indian citizenship to a matter of conferred "grace" rather than inherent "right". The danger, he writes, lies in allowing a single community's narrative to dominate the national imagination—making minorities feel like guests in their own homeland. But history, if read wisely, also offers lessons in pluralism. In a letter to Aurangzeb, Shivaji reminded the emperor of his illustrious forebear Akbar: "To rule justly is to understand the strength of diversity." This was more than shrewd diplomacy, it was a possible vision of shared destiny. It is this Shivaji—thoughtful, strategic and inclusive—we must remember today. Not merely a warrior king, but a statesman who understood that the strength of a nation lies in its capacity to absorb differences without fragmenting.

In reinterpreting our past, we must be wary of oversimplification. Every era is complex, every ruler contradictory. Turning history into a binary of heroes and villains may satisfy the politics of the moment, but it impoverishes the intellect of a civilisation. There is a fine line between reclaiming heritage and reliving vendettas. As a society, we must ask whether we are investing enough in the future or simply mortgaging it to settle scores from centuries ago. India is poised to become one of the world's top economies. But no real development can occur if national energy is constantly drained by cultural score-settling. The arc of history bends forward—only if we let it. It is said that those who are obsessed with the past often forfeit the future. Let us ensure we don't become a nation that forgets this truth.

(Aroon Purie)